ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Sequence of tenses and selective backshift

Choose whether to backshift based on temporal viewpoint, current validity and rhetorical responsibility rather than applying a mechanical rule. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use sequence of tenses and selective backshift to preserve the intended relationship between original utterance, report time and current truth status while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Choose whether to backshift based on temporal viewpoint, current validity and rhetorical responsibility rather than applying a mechanical rule.

MODEL

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.

reporting time + proposition time + current-validity decision

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main sequence of tenses and selective backshift patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses preserve the intended relationship between original utterance, report time and current truth status.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in research reporting, journalism, testimony and complex narrative.

Build meaning before form

Choose whether to backshift based on temporal viewpoint, current validity and rhetorical responsibility rather than applying a mechanical rule.

What sequence of tenses and selective backshift communicates

Choose whether to backshift based on temporal viewpoint, current validity and rhetorical responsibility rather than applying a mechanical rule.

The central purpose is to preserve the intended relationship between original utterance, report time and current truth status. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The witness said that she had left before midnight.	an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point
The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.	a proposition presented as still valid now
The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.	a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: reporting time + proposition time + current-validity decision. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Backshifted report	past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense	The witness said that she had left before midnight.
Current-validity retention	past reporting verb + present tense	The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.
Deliberate distancing	backshift to mark reduced commitment	The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point	Backshifted report
a proposition presented as still valid now	Current-validity retention
a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance	Deliberate distancing

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in research reporting, journalism, testimony and complex narrative. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
reporting time	proposition time	current-validity decision

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: preserve the intended relationship between original utterance, report time and current truth status.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits research reporting, journalism, testimony and complex narrative.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Backshifted report	past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense	The witness said that she had left before midnight.
Current-validity retention	past reporting verb + present tense	The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.
Deliberate distancing	backshift to mark reduced commitment	The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The witness said that she had left before midnight.	an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point
The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.	a proposition presented as still valid now
The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.	a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not backshift beyond what the event sequence requires.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not retain the present merely because the source used it if current validity is disputed.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not imply falsity solely through backshift without supporting context.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point?

OPTIONS The witness said that she had left before midnight. · The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding. · The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a proposition presented as still valid now?

OPTIONS The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding. · The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure. · The witness said that she had left before midnight.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance?

OPTIONS The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure. · The witness said that she had left before midnight. · The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The witness said that she had left before midnight.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point · a proposition presented as still valid now · a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a proposition presented as still valid now · a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance · an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance · an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point · a proposition presented as still valid now

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The witness said that she had left before midnight." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Backshifted report / Current-validity retention / Deliberate distancing · Gap 2: an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point / a proposition presented as still valid now / a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Current-validity retention / Deliberate distancing / Backshifted report · Gap 2: a proposition presented as still valid now / a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance / an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Deliberate distancing / Backshifted report / Current-validity retention · Gap 2: a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance / an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point / a proposition presented as still valid now

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point: _____. Choose the model that expresses a proposition presented as still valid now: _____. Choose the model that expresses a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance: _____. Choose the model built with past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense: _____. Choose the model built with past reporting verb + present tense: _____. Choose the model built with backshift to mark reduced commitment: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding. · The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure. · The witness said that she had left before midnight.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The witness said that she _____ before midnight. The report stated that the _____ to flooding. The spokesperson _____ entirely secure. State the full structural pattern for Backshifted report: _____. State the full structural pattern for Current-validity retention: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The witness said, “I left before midnight.”” using the Backshifted report pattern to express an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The report made a claim that remains current.” using the Current-validity retention pattern to express a proposition presented as still valid now.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The spokesperson said the system is secure, but the writer does not endorse it.” using the Deliberate distancing pattern to express a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The witness said, “I left before midnight.”” using the Backshifted report pattern to express an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Backshifted report to express an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Current-validity retention to express a proposition presented as still valid now, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Deliberate distancing to express a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The witness said that she had left before midnight.

Backshifted report is the best match because an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point.

A2

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.

Current-validity retention is the best match because a proposition presented as still valid now.

A3

The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

Deliberate distancing is the best match because a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance.

A4

an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point

The Backshifted report pattern communicates an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point.

A5

a proposition presented as still valid now

The Current-validity retention pattern communicates a proposition presented as still valid now.

A6

a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance

The Deliberate distancing pattern communicates a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Backshifted report / an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point

The structure belongs to the Backshifted report pattern. Its communicative purpose is an earlier embedded event viewed from a past report point.

B2

Current-validity retention / a proposition presented as still valid now

The structure belongs to the Current-validity retention pattern. Its communicative purpose is a proposition presented as still valid now.

B3

Deliberate distancing / a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance

The structure belongs to the Deliberate distancing pattern. Its communicative purpose is a reported claim from which the writer maintains distance.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The witness said that she had left before midnight.

Backshifted report: past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense.

C2

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.

Current-validity retention: past reporting verb + present tense.

C3

The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

Deliberate distancing: backshift to mark reduced commitment.

C4

The witness said that she had left before midnight.

Backshifted report: past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense.

C5

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.

Current-validity retention: past reporting verb + present tense.

C6

The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

Deliberate distancing: backshift to mark reduced commitment.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

had left

Backshifted report requires “had left” in this model. past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense.

D2

river is highly vulnerable

Current-validity retention requires “river is highly vulnerable” in this model. past reporting verb + present tense.

D3

claimed that the system was

Deliberate distancing requires “claimed that the system was” in this model. backshift to mark reduced commitment.

D4

past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense

Backshifted report is built as past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense.

D5

past reporting verb + present tense

Current-validity retention is built as past reporting verb + present tense.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The witness said that she had left before midnight.

past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended backshifted report effect.

E2

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding.

past reporting verb + present tense. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended current-validity retention effect.

E3

The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure.

backshift to mark reduced commitment. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended deliberate distancing effect.

E4

The witness said that she had left before midnight.

past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended backshifted report effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The witness said that she had left before midnight. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses past reporting verb + past/perfect embedded tense accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The report stated that the river is highly vulnerable to flooding. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses past reporting verb + present tense accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The spokesperson claimed that the system was entirely secure. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses backshift to mark reduced commitment accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____